

JUSTICE OFFICIAL TO MEET EPSTEIN’S TOP AIDE

A federal attorney says he plans to ask Ghislaine Maxwell, ‘What do you know?’

By MICHAEL WILNER

WASHINGTON — Up-roar over the Trump administration’s handling of files from the Jeffrey Epstein investigation continues to grip Washington, prompting the Justice Department on Tuesday to schedule an unusual meeting with Epstein’s top confidant, Ghislaine Maxwell, and the House Oversight Committee to move to subpoena her testimony amid bipartisan calls for transparency in the case.

The renewed focus on Maxwell comes amid persistent questions over President Trump’s years-long friendship with Epstein, the late and disgraced financier whose sprawling sex-trafficking ring victimized more than 200 women and girls.

Maxwell is serving a 20-year sentence in federal prison for her role in perpetuating one of the most expansive sex-trafficking rings in modern U.S. history.

It is the first time the Justice Department has approached Maxwell’s counsel for a meeting, according to the deputy attorney general, Todd Blanche, who wrote in a statement that he would take the meeting himself “to ask: What do you know?”

“No one is above the law — and no lead is off-limits,” said Blanche, formerly one of Trump’s personal attorneys.

And yet, Republicans and Democrats alike are ex-

[See Epstein, A7]



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HOUSE Speaker Mike Johnson moved to send lawmakers home early to prevent a vote on Jeffrey Epstein files.

Eaton blaze could use up state’s \$21-billion wildfire fund

Damage claims from the Eaton wildfire in Altadena could wipe out the \$21-billion fund California created to shield utilities and their customers from the cost of wildfires sparked by electric lines, according to newly released state documents.

Investigators are seeking to determine whether Southern California Edison’s equipment sparked the Jan. 7 inferno, which killed 18 people and destroyed 9,000 homes. If Edison is found responsible, “the resulting claims may be substantial enough to fully exhaust the Fund,” state officials who administer the wildfire fund wrote in a draft annual report to the Legislature.

The seven-member state Catastrophe Response Council, which oversees the fund, is scheduled to meet Thursday to discuss how potential damage claims from the Eaton

New data show
that money to
protect utilities
and their clients
may be drained
by claims from
Jan. 7 inferno

By Melody Petersen

fire could affect it.

Concerns are already emerging that, should Edison be found liable, it would have little incentive to keep damage claims from becoming excessive since the utility itself would be spared from covering most of the costs.

“Are we impressing on the utilities that they need to settle claims with diligence?” wrote one of the council members, according to meeting materials released ahead of Thursday’s meeting. “Since the claims they settle are just passed on to us, they don’t have much incentive to keep claims low.”

Asked for comment on that statement, Edison spokeswoman Kathleen Dunleavy said that officials “need to be wise and cautious about how this money is spent.”

“We agree [See Claims, A14]

LAUSD testing scores reach new high

Pupils make gains in English and math for a second year, topping pre-pandemic results.

By HOWARD BLUME

After years of struggling to recover from deep pandemic setbacks, Los Angeles Unified students have achieved a “new high water mark,” with math and English scores rising across all tested grades for the second straight year, surpassing results from before the 2020 campus closures, Supt. Alberto Carvalho said.

Two years of incremental gains at every tested grade level is generally considered solid evidence that instruction is moving in the right direction, said Carvalho, along with education experts.

“The coolest thing is that the district, despite all that this community went through, has now reached the highest-ever performance at all levels in English language arts and math,” Carvalho said in an interview with The Times. He formally announced the results Tuesday during his annual

[See Education, A8]

Encino suspect allegedly called 911

Police still didn’t find bodies of ‘Idol’ exec and her husband for four days, D.A. says.

By RICHARD WINTON,
LIBOR JANY
AND HANNAH FRY

The man accused of killing “American Idol” music supervisor Robin Kaye and her rock musician husband, Tom DeLuca, in their home in Encino allegedly called 911 after the crime, the county’s top prosecutor said, yet it still took four more days to discover their bodies.

Los Angeles County Dist. Atty. Nathan Hochman said the couple were shot with their own gun. The new details in the slayings of Kaye and DeLuca were revealed during a Monday town hall meeting in Encino, where hundreds of residents gathered to express frustration about a string of recent

[See Slayings, A14]



ALLEN J. SCHABEN Los Angeles Times

EVA ALBUJA surveys landslide damage near her Rancho Palos Verdes home.

‘Not safe’ to build, city says

After two years of landslide movement, officials in Rancho Palos Verdes want ban on new development

By GRACE TOOHEY

After almost two years of unprecedented landslide movement that has up-ended life across much of the picturesque Portuguese Bend area of the Palos Verdes Peninsula, officials want to permanently ban new construction in the landslide zone.

The proposed ordinance, which has drawn backlash from some property owners, would prohibit construction of new homes or additions in the area — even on vacant lots, of which many remain. However, it would permit repairs, restoration efforts or even the replacement of existing homes within a residence’s established footprint. The measure will be considered next month by the Rancho Palos Verdes

City Council.

“This is not an area that should accommodate new residences,” said City Manager Ara Mihranian. “We are at a point where we have seen such severe damage. ... I’ve got to give recommendations that have public safety and public interest in mind.”

The proposed ban comes as city officials struggle to respond to the major increase in land movement that began in late 2023 and peaked last summer, when some areas recorded up to a foot a week of movement. While the movement has slowed considerably, or even stopped in some areas, several spots are continuing to see 3 to 4 inches of sliding a week, according to the city’s latest records.

Though the area has long been known for recurring issues from a complex of an-

cient landslides that re-emerged in the 1950s, the damage over the last two years has occurred at a scale and rate never before seen. Homes fractured, roads became warped beyond use and area utilities shut off electricity and gas services to much of the region after repeated damage, though some sections have since been restored.

As of this month, the city has designated 20 homes too dangerous to enter and another 38 as having significant structural damage — enough to make parts of homes uninhabitable. At the end of last year, the federal government agreed to finance a buyout program for about 20 homes, to convert the properties into open space and limit future risk in the area.

[See Landslides, A8]

‘South Park’ team inks lucrative deals

Paramount has landed streaming rights to the series for \$300 million a year for five years.

By MEG JAMES

“South Park” creators Trey Parker and Matt Stone have scored two blockbuster deals that will pay their production company more than \$1.25 billion — ranking their pacts among the richest in television history.

Paramount Global secured the show’s exclusive global streaming rights for \$300 million a year for five years, bringing Kenny, Kyle, Stan and Cartman to the company’s digital service, Paramount+, for the first time in the U.S.

Paramount separately

extended Stone and Parker’s overall production deal for their firm, Park County. As part of that pact, Park County will receive a minimum of \$250 million a year through 2030 to make at least 50 new “South Park” episodes, according to two people familiar with the deal but not authorized to speak publicly. For now, the streaming compensation is counted toward the overall deal.

The gravity-defying deals prove that even as Hollywood studios struggle financially, they are willing to pay big bucks to proven hitmakers.

“In a business where nobody knows anything, there is one certainty: ‘South Park’ always wins,” said former Comedy Central chief Doug Herzog, who brought

[See ‘South Park,’ A11]

A shake-up of top ranks at LAPD

Chief signals how he will remake the agency as it faces various challenges. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Millions of pools are recalled

Safety measure follows drowning deaths of nine kids in above-ground products. **BUSINESS, A9**

Weather
Clouds, then sun.
L.A. Basin: 79/62. **B6**

Markets **A11**
Opinion Voices **A12**

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HEAVY METAL PIONEER

Fans leave flowers at Ozzy Osbourne’s star in Hollywood. The Black Sabbath singer and reality TV figure died Tuesday at 76. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**